

Month Cycle Table Rulebook

This document describes the finished rules used by the current version of the game.

1. Overview

Month Cycle Table is a 4-player draw-discard card game built around a 96-card custom deck.

Core flow:

- each player normally holds 5 total cards
- on your turn, you draw to 6
- if those 6 cards form a legal winning pattern, you may win
- otherwise you discard back to 5
- other players may claim that discard in priority order
- scoring uses exactly one 6-card winning pattern

The game is built around:

- Month: 1 to 12
- Color: G, R, Y, K, B, W
- Wind: N, S, E, W
- each month-color card has a unique month-color identity
- each wind-color card has a unique wind-color identity and no month

2. Components

The deck has 96 unique cards.

2.1 Month Cards (72 cards)

Each month card has:

- a month from 1 to 12
- a color: G, R, Y, K, B, or W

Deck structure:

- months repeat every 12 cards
- the first 60 cards use the original five colors: G, R, Y, K, B
- the final 12 cards are white cards
- each month appears exactly 6 times in the deck
- each color appears exactly 12 times among month cards

2.2 Wind Cards (24 cards)

Each wind card has:

- a wind: N (North), S (South), E (East), or W (West)

- a color: `G`, `R`, `Y`, `K`, `B`, or `W`
- ****no month****

Wind cards participate in color-based requirements but cannot satisfy month-based requirements.

3. Players, Seats, and Dealer

The game uses exactly `4` players:

- East
- South
- West
- North

At the start of a new match:

- all players begin with `18` points
- a random dealer is chosen
- that dealer becomes `East`

****Seat wind (home wind):****

- East player's home wind is `E`
- South player's home wind is `S`
- West player's home wind is `W`
- North player's home wind is `N`

Dealer rule:

- if East wins the hand, East remains dealer for the next hand
- otherwise dealer passes to the next player

East starts each hand, but East does not receive a special scoring bonus.

4. Match Structure

A match lasts up to `12` rounds.

Round flow:

- rounds are numbered `1` through `12`
- after round `12`, if one player leads, the match ends
- if round `12` ends in a tie for first, the game enters sudden death
- sudden death continues until the tie breaks

Early match end:

- if any player falls to `0` points or below, the match ends immediately

5. Hand Setup

At the start of each hand:

- shuffle all `96` cards
- deal `5` cards to each player
- the remaining `76` cards become the wall
- East takes the first turn

6. Hand Structure

Each player has:

- a concealed hand
- an open area

For win checking, a player's total hand is:

- concealed cards + open cards

Important:

- only concealed cards may be discarded
- open cards stay face-up and locked for the rest of the hand
- before drawing or claiming, a player should normally have `5` total cards
- after drawing or claiming, they temporarily have `6`

7. Turn Flow

On your turn:

1. Draw `1` card from the wall.
2. You now have `6` total cards.
3. If the 6-card hand forms a legal winning pattern, you may declare `tsumo`.
4. If you do not win, discard `1` concealed card.
5. Other players may respond to that discard.
6. If no claim succeeds, the next player takes a turn.

A player may pass a legal `tsumo` and keep playing.

8. Claims

After a discard, claims are checked in this order:

1. `ron`
2. `kan`
3. `pon`
4. `chi`

If a higher-priority claim succeeds, lower-priority claims do not happen.

8.1 Ron

`Ron` means winning on another player's discard.

Rules:

- if adding the discarded card to your current total hand creates a legal winning 6-card pattern, you may `ron`
- multiple players may `ron` the same discard
- each `ron` winner is paid separately by the discarder

8.2 Chi

`Chi` is not a sequence claim in this game.

Rules:

- only the next player in turn order may `chi`
- no sequence is required
- `chi` simply takes the discarded card and places it into your open area
- after `chi`, you must discard one concealed card

Because `chi` opens exactly one visible card, it is the smallest way to build gear.

8.3 Pon

`Pon` is month-based for month cards and wind-based for wind cards.

Rules for month cards:

- you may `pon` only if you already have exactly `3` cards of the same month as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-month cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after `pon`, you must discard one concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- you may `pon` only if you already have exactly `3` cards of the same wind as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-wind cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after `pon`, you must discard one concealed card

In practice, `pon` creates an open block of `4` visible cards.

8.4 Kan

`Kan` is also month-based for month cards and wind-based for wind cards.

Rules for month cards:

- you may `kan` only if you already have exactly `4` cards of the same month as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-month cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after `kan`, you must discard one concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- you may `kan` only if you already have exactly `4` cards of the same wind as the discard across your concealed and open cards
- all of those same-wind cards, plus the claimed discard, become open
- after `kan`, you must discard one concealed card

In practice, `kan` creates an open block of `5` visible cards.

8.5 Self Kan

On your own turn, you may also declare a `self kan`.

Rules for month cards:

- if your concealed hand contains `5` cards of the same month, you may open them immediately as a `kan`
- after `self kan`, you must discard `1` concealed card

Rules for wind cards:

- if your concealed hand contains `5` cards of the same wind, you may open them immediately as a `kan`
- after `self kan`, you must discard `1` concealed card

In practice, `self kan` converts a concealed 5-card block into an open 5-card block without needing an opponent discard.

9. Wind Discard Rules

9.1 Home Wind Discard

When you discard your ****home wind**** (the wind matching your seat):

- `ron` is checked first
- if no player wins by `ron`, you ****may**** choose to move one concealed card from your hand to your open area
- if you do, that opened card is placed face-up before `kan`, `pon`, or `chi` respond to the discarded wind
- opponents may claim the discarded wind card via `ron`, `kan`, `pon`, or `chi`
- opponents ****may not**** claim the card you just opened
- if you have no concealed cards other than the wind you are discarding, you may skip the optional open

9.2 Guest Wind Discard

When you discard a wind card that is ****not**** your home wind:

- the discard proceeds normally
- no additional effects apply

10. Winning

There are two win methods:

- `Tsumo`: win on your own draw
- `Ron`: win on another player's discard

A winning hand is always exactly `6` total cards.

If a 6-card hand matches more than one pattern:

- remove any pattern that fails the gear rule
- from the remaining valid patterns, apply any gear-based point reduction
- use the highest-point result after gear is applied

10.1 Wind Card Pattern Restrictions

Wind cards have ****no month****. Therefore, wind cards cannot be used in any pattern that requires month properties, including:

- Skip
- Run
- Triple Pair
- Twin Tone Pairs
- Parity Pairs
- Twin Triples
- Tri Tone Triples
- Parity Triples
- Escort
- Split Escort
- Mono Skip
- Mono Run

Wind cards ****can**** be used in `Mono` (all same color), `Crown`, `Grand Crown`, and all wind-specific patterns listed in Section 15.

11. Gear Rule

Gear is based on the literal number of visible open cards in your open area. Some higher-value sets can still score with lower gear, but they score as a smaller point tier until you have enough open cards.

Current gear requirements:

- `3pt` requires at least `3` open cards
- `6pt` requires at least `2` open cards
- with exactly `2` open cards, it scores `3pt`
- with `3` or more open cards, it scores the full `6pt`
- `9pt` requires at least `1` open card
- with exactly `1` open card, it scores `3pt`
- with exactly `2` open cards, it scores `6pt`
- with `3` or more open cards, it scores the full `9pt`
- `12pt` is always valid, but gear changes the score

- with `0` to `3` open cards, it scores `6pt`
- with exactly `4` open cards, it scores `9pt`
- with `5` open cards, it scores the full `12pt`
- `15pt` is always valid, but gear changes the score
- with `0` to `3` open cards, it scores `9pt`
- with exactly `4` open cards, it scores `12pt`
- with `5` open cards, it scores the full `15pt`

This applies to both:

- `tsumo`
- `ron`

Examples:

- one `chi` gives `1` open card
- two `chi` claims give `2` open cards
- one `pon` usually gives `4` open cards
- one `kan` usually gives `5` open cards
- a home wind discard with optional open gives `1` open card

12. Round Bonus

Each round has a target month equal to the round number.

Examples:

- round `1` targets month `1`
- round `5` targets month `5`
- round `12` targets month `12`

Bonus rule:

- if you win in round `N`
- and your final winning 6-card hand contains month `N`
- you gain `+3` points once

Important:

- the bonus applies only once per winning hand
- it applies to both `tsumo` and `ron`
- it can raise a `15pt` hand to `18pt`
- sudden death rounds do not have a numbered month target

13. Home Wind Bonus

If your winning 6-card hand contains your **home wind** (the wind matching your seat), you gain `+3` points once.

Important:

- the bonus applies only once per winning hand
- it applies to both `tsumo` and `ron`
- it stacks with the round month bonus
- a `15pt` hand with both bonuses scores `21pt`

14. Settlement

14.1 Tsumo

On `tsumo`:

- the winner gains the hand's full value
- the other `3` players each pay one third of that value

Because all legal totals are divisible by `3`, settlement is always clean.

Examples:

- `3pt` tsumo: each opponent pays `1`
- `12pt` tsumo: each opponent pays `4`
- `18pt` tsumo: each opponent pays `6`
- `21pt` tsumo: each opponent pays `7`

14.2 Ron

On `ron`:

- the discarder pays the full value
- the winner gains the full value

14.3 Multiple Ron

If multiple players `ron` the same discard:

- each winner scores separately
- the discarder pays each winner in full

15. Winning Patterns

All patterns below use exactly `6` cards.

15.1 3-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
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Mono	All 6 cards share one color	At least 3 open cards
Skip	All 6 cards are all odd months or all even months, all 6 months are different, and all 6 colors are different	
Run	Six different months in order; if any of those cards are open, the open months must also be consecutive within	
Wind	All 6 cards are wind cards, with all 6 colors present	At least 3 open cards

15.2 6-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
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Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Triple Pair	3 pairs from 3 consecutive months	2 open cards scores 3pt; 3+ open cards scores 6pt
Wind Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different winds	2 open cards scores 3pt; 3+ open cards scores 6pt
Twin Tone Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different months, using at most 2 colors total	2 open cards scores 3pt; 3+ open cards scores 6pt
Parity Pairs	3 pairs from 3 different months, all odd or all even	2 open cards scores 3pt; 3+ open cards scores 6pt

15.3 9-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Twin Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of a consecutive month	1 open card scores 3pt; 2 open cards scores 6pt; 3+ open cards scores 9pt
Wind Triples	3 cards of one wind and 3 cards of another wind	1 open card scores 3pt; 2 open cards scores 6pt; 3+ open cards scores 9pt
Tri Tone Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of another month, using at most 3 colors total	1 open card scores 3pt; 2 open cards scores 6pt; 3+ open cards scores 9pt
Parity Triples	3 cards of one month and 3 cards of another month, all odd or all even	1 open card scores 3pt; 2 open cards scores 6pt; 3+ open cards scores 9pt

15.4 12-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Crown	Either: 5 of one month plus 1 neighboring month with all 6 colors present; or 6 of one month with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt
Escort	4 of one month plus 2 matching cards from either the previous or next month, with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt
Split Escort	4 of one month plus 1 previous and 1 next month, with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt
Compass	N, S, E, W plus either 1 pair or 2 cards in sequence, with all 6 colors present	0-3 open cards scores 6pt; 4 open cards scores 12pt

15.5 15-point patterns

Pattern	Requirement	Gear
Mono Skip	All 6 cards share one color and are all odd months or all even months	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 15pt
Mono Run	Six different months in order, all sharing one color	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 15pt
Grand Crown	Either: all 6 cards are the current round month; or all 6 cards are your home wind	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 15pt
Mono Compass	N, S, E, W plus 2 cards in sequence, all sharing one color	0-3 open cards scores 9pt; 4 open cards scores 15pt

Notes on the 15-point patterns:

- `Skip` means all odd months or all even months, with all 6 colors and all 6 months different.
- `Run` means a 6-month consecutive run.
- `Mono Skip` means a `Skip` played in a single color lane.
- `Grand Crown` means collecting all 6 cards of the round's target month, or all 6 cards of your seat wind. In sudden death there is no target month, so only the home wind branch is available.
- `Crown` on the wind side means all 6 cards are the same guest wind. If all 6 cards are your home wind instead, that is `Grand Crown`.
- `Compass` uses all four winds plus either a month pair or a 2-month sequence, with all 6 colors represented.
- `Mono Compass` uses all four winds plus a 2-month sequence, all in a single color.
- Only `Run` requires any open cards inside that pattern to form a consecutive block of months within the completed run.

16. End of Hand

A hand ends when:

- a player wins by `tsumo`
- one or more players win by `ron`
- the wall is exhausted

If the wall is exhausted:

- the hand is a draw
- no one scores

- dealer rotates normally unless East had won before the draw, which did not happen

17. End of Match

The match ends when one of these happens:

- a player falls to `0` or below
- round `12` ends and one player is alone in first place
- sudden death ends with one player alone in first place

If round `12` ends tied for first:

- no one wins the match yet
- play continues in sudden death rounds until the tie breaks

18. Practical Notes

- Odd/even patterns use the card's hidden deck position parity. Each month contains both odd and even cards.
- The month labels are numeric `1` to `12`.
- The color labels are abbreviated: `G`, `R`, `Y`, `K`, `B`, `W`.
- The wind labels are abbreviated: `N`, `S`, `E`, `W`.
- Open-card count matters a lot because of gear. A beautiful hand may still be invalid if it does not meet the required visible open count for its point tier.
- Wind cards have no month and therefore cannot satisfy any pattern requirement that references months, months being consecutive, or month parity.